

Group 2
10/29/25

Sports Betting Ethnographic Study

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Background

Rise of Legal Sports Betting:

Since the 2018 Supreme Court decision (Murphy v. NCAA), sports betting has been legalized in over 30 U.S. states, transforming it from a niche activity into a mainstream form of entertainment.

Cultural Integration:

Sports betting has become deeply tied to sports fandom. Betting odds are being shown on broadcasts, and apps like FanDuel and DraftKings have become big household names

Digital Accessibility:

With sports betting services being mobile, apps have made betting more accessible, allowing users to place bets anytime and anywhere. This has changed how fans engage with sports and with each other

Social and Behavioral Aspects:

Sports betting often occurs in social contexts. You often see friends gathered for football Sundays, at a restaurant watching their favorite soccer team, etc. This all happens among friends, fantasy leagues, and online communities. All of this blends competition, risk, and community identity

Why This Study?

- Sports betting has become a huge part of our culture and the formation of social connections
- Conducting an ethnographic observation study would help us to get a better understanding as to how sports betting has been integrated into people's lives and would allow us to see how it has changed the way in which people relate to each other
- Conducting an observational study would allow us to see and feel the impact for ourselves to get a deeper understanding on the topic

Research Objectives

Understanding Behavior:

To explore how and why individuals engage in sports betting

Is it about thrill, social connection, financial gain, or habit?

And to explore how they use player and team statistics to determine how they will place their bets

Cultural Insight:

To understand how betting culture shapes fan identity, communication, and group dynamics within sporting communities.

Study Design

Participants

- Our participants will consist of sports fans that are 21 and older who participate in sports betting and will make to sure to get informed consent from each participant
- We will have a total of 8 participants with each group member observing two participants

Recruitment Strategy

- We will be contacting sports fans that we know and asking them to participate in our observation study

Setting

- Anywhere the participants felt comfortable.

Data Collection

Method

- We will be observing the participants' patterns and behaviors as they strategize and place their bets
- We will also have them take a screen recording while they are on the app and placing their bets
- Throughout the study, we will just be asking questions to clarify any decisions or actions that they take
- Track recurring reasons for betting
- Also their social interaction during sports related conversation

Tools & Devices

- They will need to have a sports betting account and should be able to access it either on their phone, laptop, iPad, or any other device that they may use to place their bets

Data Analysis

Strategy And Risk Management

exclusively use the Fanatics Sportsbook app because of the "fair play" rule that refunds bets when a player is injured mid-game

explained the concept of "control" in betting, referring to how predictable or manageable a bet feels

used blogs, videos, and Discord communities to help inform their decisions.

a single bet is less risky but a parlay gives you more money quicker.

only uses parlays because single bets require more cash to be actually worth doing them

rotate between multiple betting apps to take advantage of bonus bets and promotions, allowing them to spend less of their own money.

use of past stats to make data driven decisions

risk-averse

engages with multiple platform

Monitoring Player health

multi platform odds comparason

low value bets

Switching between different apps

Statistics filtering for better predictions

Psychology

a little
disappointed
but it was
money he was
ok with losing.

frustrated
at
avoidable
losses

excited at the
prospect of
winning because
of previous high-
value wins

motivated
primarily by
the goal of
making
money

recent betting-
related scandals
do not affect
their willingness
to participate

confident
and
excited

mild
thrill

appeared
anxious
about their
selections

keeps coming
back to sports
bet because of
the potential to
make it lucrative.

bets just for
fun because it
makes the
games a bit
more exciting

Decision Making

Conducted
2min
research
using blogs

efficient and
methodical 5
min research
process

\$10
three-leg
parlay

selected props
for a five-leg
parlay for 10\$

Received
secondary
input from
friend

conservative
choices

reliance on
sports
knowledge



analytical/data-
driven

Fan Identity

experienced
sports better
who watches
a wide variety
of sports

digital/fantasy
interaction

Team
Loyalty
Influence

Player
Loyalty >
Team
Identity

primarily
watches
basketball

Personas



Robert Garcia

Robert is a passionate football fan who loves watching football with his dad every Sunday. He follows the sport closely every week and uses apps like FanDuel and Real to analyze player stats before placing bets. For Robert, sports betting adds excitement to the game and helps him connect with his dad.

Personal Information

- Age: 21
- Gender: Male
- Ethnicity: Hispanic

Goals

- Win money while betting on his favorite team
- Make better predictions
- Strengthen connections through sports bets

Needs

- Tools that reduce risk without removing the excitement of fandom
- Seamless navigation between data and betting interfaces
- Less cognitive overload when analyzing many data points

Frustrations

- Information overload throughout app
- Has to use a different app for more in-depth stats
- Avoids placing risky bets due to unpredictability

“Football is something my dad and I always watched together — betting just gives us something more to cheer for.”



Samuel Jackson

Samuel is an analytically minded bettor who likes to compare odds, tracks performance data, and maximize potential payouts. He is calm and calculated, and prefers parlays that reward deep research rather than emotional guesswork. He uses the DraftKings app to make data-backed predictions and help him get the best payout and thrill.

Personal Information

- Age: 23
- Gender: Male
- Ethnicity: White

Needs

- Ways to save and track changing odds to refine picks
- Tools that reduce risk without removing the excitement of fandom
- A clear understanding of how loyalty might bias his choices

Goals

- Maximize profit potential by securing the best odds available
- Save and track odds changes over time for smarter betting
- Build confidence before committing to a complex parlay

Frustrations

- Delays decisions due to too many variables
- Doesn't always feel confident in his bets
- Loses bets by very little

"If I'm going to bet, I want to be sure — the numbers have to make sense."

Link To Journey Map :

<https://miro.com/app/board/uXjVJoDuwAg=/>

1. Strategy & Decision-Making

Bettors use multiple tools and apps (DraftKings, ESPN, fantasy dashboards) to guide decisions.

Past experience and historical performance influence choices.

Bettors balance risk vs. reward, often placing small stakes for big potential payouts.

Conclusion: Within the sports betting community, bettors are not simply gambling impulsively, but rather they approach it with tactics, systems, and thought processes.

Motivation & Psychology

Primary motivators: excitement, thrill, and potential financial gain.

Bettors experience a range of emotions: confident, anxious, frustrated, or mildly thrilled.

Persistent engagement: even after losses or recent scandals, they continue betting.

Conclusion: Bettors aren't only investing money, they invest their emotions. They love the emotional volatility and as proof of this when bettors acknowledge that scandals compromise fairness most still continue betting.

Fan & Player Identity

Player loyalty often outweighs team loyalty in betting decisions.

Fantasy leagues and digital platforms shape how fans interact with sports.

Social interactions (friends, group chats, co-workers) influence betting behavior.

Conclusion: The increasing influence of player loyalty suggests that modern sports betting is becoming an individualized practice where personal expertise and player allegiance outweigh traditional team-based fandom.

Outcomes & Perceived Control

Betting outcomes are unpredictable; losses are common and accepted, especially with small stakes. Planning and research help, but ultimate success is out of the bettor's control.

Bettors focus on the excitement of wins and the learning opportunities from losses.

Conclusion: The community has shows a growth mindset and feels that betting is a skill that can be refined which partially explains why participation continues even after losing streaks.

Themes / Conclusions